



champion, the Socceroos, the strongest contenders in the group and one of the title favourites.

Interestingly, the last time India played in the Asian Cup in Qatar, its first opponent was also Australia, and it lost 0-4. Though the Socceroos have changed three managers since, the current side, under head coach Graham Arnold, would be an even tougher nut to crack, having reached the round of 16 of the FIFA World Cup 2022.

India, on the other hand, will look to scrape the barrel, having lost three of its first-team regulars — center-back Anwar Ali, who is recuperating from an ankle injury; Ashique Kuruniyan, who is ruled out with a torn ACL (anterior cruciate ligament); and Jeakson Singh, who could not recover from shoulder surgery in time.

A better showing in Qatar

India returns to Qatar — moved from China due to Covid-19 challenges — for the Asian Cup after

a forgettable outing in 2011, when it failed to get a single point under head coach Bob Houghton, losing to Australia, Bahrain, and South Korea.

Goalkeeper Subrata Paul had then risen to hero's status against South Korea, making 15 saves and earning the nickname 'Spiderman'. This time, however, India, having risen 40 spots in the rankings since, will look to celebrate and relish team accolades against Asian heavyweights.

Only two players from the 2011 Asian Cup squad — Sunil Chhetri and Gurpreet Singh Sandhu — are part of the 2024 edition, and their leadership will play a crucial role in inspiring the team.

Stimac's boys showed a lot of promise in early 2023, winning the Tri-Nations Series, Intercontinental Cup, and SAFF Championship by July, but struggled to assert control over higher-ranked opponents later on, winning just once in their last five games. Their performance against

Home advantage: Qatar, on home soil, will be looking to successfully defend the AFC Asian Cup it won for the first time in 2019. GETTYIMAGES

Iraq in the King's Cup, playing a higher line with fluid passing in the final third along with quick set-pieces, will be the ace up their sleeves against three counter-attacking sides in the Asian Cup.

The head coach, however, has underlined the lack of preparation time. He has maintained that the country should not expect too much from a team with hardly two weeks in the national camp after Indian Super League duties.

"Let's stop talking about the Asian Cup. We didn't get what we wanted. I was very clear: if you give me time, I might provide results for you. Without time, do not ask about results or anything like that. Just forget it," Stimac said.